



IIT ROORKEE



NPTEL ONLINE
CERTIFICATION COURSE

Public Speaking

Lecture 05- Role of Ethics in Public Speaking

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On Ethics

- ❑ The Cambridge Dictionary of Philosophy states that the word **ethics** is “commonly used interchangeably with ‘morality’ ... and sometimes it is used more narrowly to mean the moral principles of a particular tradition, group or individual.”
- ❑ Richard William Paul and Linda Elder define **ethics** as “a set of concepts and principles that guide us in determining what behaviour helps or harms sentient creatures”.
- ❑ Paul and Elder state that most people confuse **ethics** with behaving in accordance with social conventions, religious beliefs and the law and don’t treat ethics as a stand-alone concept.

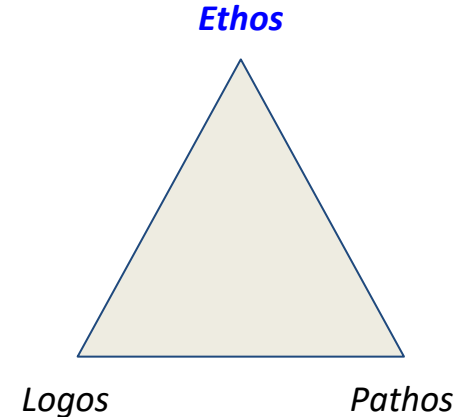
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- Ethics is moral philosophy.
 - It is the study of the values and guidelines.
 - Ethics deals with voluntary actions.
 - Ethical values are culturally-oriented.
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- “Do unto others as you would have them do unto you.”



Ethos and Ethics

- As discussed in the previous lecture, *ethos* forms an indispensable corner of Aristotelian rhetorical triangle.
- The term ethos can be synonymously understood as “an appeal to ethics.”
- The conscience of the speaker plays a stronger part to establish the credibility of his/her speech.
- The nature of the effect caused by a speaker, be it good or bad, is solely determined by the ethical appeal of the speech.



Ethics in Public Speaking

- ❖ Public speaking shall rather be a rhetorical *art of persuasion*, than dubious trickery of manipulation.
- ❖ The speaker with the power of speech must be aware of his/her ethical responsibilities.
- ❖ Roman rhetorician Quintilian said “the ideal of speechmaking is the good person speaking well.”

Brutus' Speech

Be patient till the last.
Romans, countrymen, and lovers!
Hear me for my cause, and be silent, that
you may hear: believe me for mine honour,
and have respect to mine honour,
that you may believe: censure me in your
wisdom,
and awake your senses,
that you may the better judge. (Act III,
Scene ii)

Antony's Speech

Friends, Romans, countrymen, lend me your
ears;
I come to bury Caesar, not to praise him.
The evil that men do lives after them;
The good is oft interred with their bones;
So let it be with Caesar.
[...]
Come I to speak in Caesar's funeral.
He was my friend, faithful and just to me:
But Brutus says he was ambitious;
And Brutus is an honourable man. (Act
III, Scene ii)

VENI
VIDI
VICI

Ethical Guidelines for Public Speaking

- The speech, in general, should be for the benefit for the **greater goodwill** of listeners than the speaker's personal interests.
- **Get the facts right:** The more thorough and well researched the content is, lesser the chance of ethical deviance or dubiousness.
- Humankind relies and thrives on honesty and mutual trust. Thus, an ethical speaker should try to provide **words of reliability**.

Caution in Speech

A speaker must exercise caution while developing an ethically sound speech. S/he should refrain from the following:

- ❖ Cooked-up data or statistics.
- ❖ Equipping irrelevant quotes.
- ❖ Poor oral citation strength.
- ❖ Failing to bring the bigger picture.
- ❖ Lack of strong evidence to back their opinions.
- ❖ Insensitive to a particular individual/ socio-ethnic group and culture.
- ❖ Lacking dignity and politeness.

Plagiarism in Speech

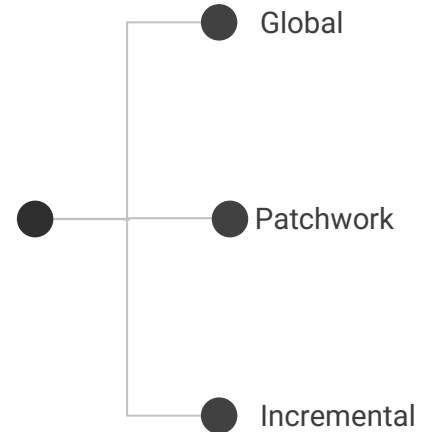
- ❖ A strong speech shall arise from one's heart boosted with emotional feelings and intellectual fervour.
- ❖ However, if the speaker chooses to merely read a full speech, an excerpt or even a quote from a third-party and fails to acknowledge the source—then the speaker indulges in a serious ethical crime called plagiarism.
- ❖ An ideal speaker shall refrain from putting up a fake impression by stealing someone else's speech—which, in fact, defeats the purpose of public speaking i.e, *to exchange one's own opinion and thoughts* on the subject of a critical matter.

Types of Plagiarism

Stephen Lucas jots down three kinds of plagiarism in public speaking in his book “The Art of Public Speaking.”

 Global Plagiarism: It is a blatant theft of incorporating content completely from a third party source, without any acknowledgement.

3 types of Plagiarism



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- ❑ Patchwork Plagiarism: As the name suggests, it is stealing excerpts from multiple sources and combining it into your personal speech.
- ❑ Incremental Plagiarism: It includes usage of quotes or paraphrasing original ideas of others without due credits given.

One must be careful with the last form of plagiarism as it is most common mistake carried out by speakers when delivering public speeches.

Consequences of Plagiarism

- ❖ Public speaking as verbal talent posits itself as a “cause” with clear motive to “effect” the intended audience.
- ❖ And if the so-called “cause” is sourced to plagiarism in itself, then the latter “effect” shall be equally misleading.
- ❖ The consequences of a speaker getting charged of plagiarism is both **interpersonal and intra-personal**.
- ❖ The speaker shall lose credibility, power of speech, reputation and even considerable amount of money when sued for liability.

Oral Citations

- Quotes and paraphrases are inevitable part of a public speech.
- A speaker must refer to the words of great thinkers or novel ideas to back up their opinions and give credibility to their speech.
- Such reference to an individual or a particular source must be clearly routed for listener's convenience.

Ethical Listening

- If one end of the public speaking is held by the speaker, then the other end is completed by listeners.
- The clear-cut contact of message through channel, interferences and situation determines the efficiency of speech delivered.
- Listeners play an important role as much as speaker in order to make a public speech achieve its effect.



It blesseth him that gives and him that takes:
'Tis mightiest in the mightiest: it becomes
The throned monarch better than his crown;
(Shakespeare)

How to be a good listener?

- ✓ Pay attention to the speaker during the limited time of speech.
- ✓ Listen to the speaker without any presumption or bias.
- ✓ Practice open-mindedness.
- ✓ Express eagerness to listen and motivate speaker's confidence.
- ✓ Refrain from indulging in other activities while speech is delivered.

Ways to be ethical

- ✓ Avoid Ethnocentrism
- ✓ Avoid misquoting
- ✓ Respect the audience
- ✓ Avoid alienating the audience
- ✓ Avoid being too personal

**“In law, man is guilty when he violates the rights of others, in ethics he is guilty if he thinks of doing so.”
- Immanuel Kant**

Thank You

Works Consulted

- ❖ Lucas, Stephen E. *The Art of Public Speaking*. McGraw-Hill Book Co. International Edition, 11th Ed. 2014.
- ❖ Shakespeare, William. Julius Caesar.
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- ❖ Zaresky, David. *Public Speaking Strategy for Success*. 8th Edition, Pearson: New York, 2016.